

Religious Authority as Epistemic Architecture

Anthony Paterson

Fractal Media Infrastructure

Gracemere, Queensland, Australia

fractalmediainfrastructure@gmail.com

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Bounded Pluralism, Correction, and the Distribution of Religious Knowledge

Abstract

Philosophical discussion of religious disagreement often begins with an individual believer who encounters sincere, competent disagreement and must decide whether to reduce confidence, suspend judgement, or remain steadfast. This paper shifts the unit of analysis outward. Before disagreement reaches an individual, religious communities already possess an epistemic architecture: a patterned distribution of authority across scriptures, traditions, institutions, specialists, practices, local communities, and individual judgement. That architecture affects which disagreements become visible, whose testimony receives weight, how interpretations are stabilized, how error propagates, and whether correction remains possible. The paper distinguishes sacred sovereignty from epistemic distribution. Sacred sovereignty concerns where ultimate divine authority is claimed to reside; epistemic distribution concerns how fallible human communities interpret, transmit, contest, and apply that authority. This distinction prevents simple assumptions that monotheistic traditions must be epistemically centralized or that polytheistic traditions must be epistemically distributed. The central thesis is architectural rather than theological: given human fallibility, the distribution of epistemic authority affects the cost and recoverability of error. The paper proposes bounded pluralism as a promising middle architecture: enough shared structure to sustain continuity, combined with enough independent interpretive capacity to preserve disagreement, expose error, and permit correction without dissolving tradition.

Keywords: religious epistemology; epistemic authority; religious disagreement; testimony; tradition; social epistemology

1. Introduction

Religious disagreement is usually framed as a problem for believers. A person holds a religious belief, discovers that another sincere and apparently competent person disagrees, and must decide how that disagreement should affect confidence. Contemporary debates then ask whether rationality requires conciliation, permits steadfastness, depends on peerhood, or turns on private evidence and higher-order evidence.

Those questions matter, but they begin late. By the time two believers meet as disagreeers, much of the relevant epistemic work has already happened. Each has inherited texts, traditions, teachers, offices, institutions, practices, commentaries, testimonies, interpretive habits, and communal memories. Some disagreements were preserved; others disappeared. Some authorities became canonical; others remained local. Some interpretations acquired standing; others were excluded. Some forms of testimony were treated as credible by default; others were filtered through suspicion.

This paper calls that structured environment an epistemic architecture.

An epistemic architecture is the relatively durable pattern by which a community distributes the work of producing, preserving, interpreting, transmitting, contesting, and revising beliefs. In religious life, it answers questions such as: where may epistemic authority reside, how much weight do different authorities carry, how can authorities be challenged, how are disagreements preserved or excluded, and how does the community maintain continuity while interpretation changes?

The central claim is deliberately modest. The paper does not evaluate the truth of any religious belief, the sincerity of adherents, or the worth of any tradition. It argues instead that authority structure changes how evidence, testimony, disagreement, and error travel through a community. Given human fallibility, that structure matters philosophically. The argument is therefore conceptual and architectural: it offers a framework for clarifying religious disagreement and correction, not an empirical comparison of religious communities.

2. From Individual Disagreement to Institutional Epistemology

The epistemology of disagreement often begins with a relatively clean encounter between agents. A and B have considered a proposition, each regards the other as competent, and they discover that they disagree. The philosophical question concerns what A should now believe given B's dissent. The literature then becomes concerned with peerhood, higher-order evidence, conciliation, steadfastness, private evidence, and the possibility that religious disagreement has distinctive features (Christensen, 2007; Feldman, 2007; Benton, 2021; Pittard, 2021).

Religious communities complicate this picture in two ways.

First, religious belief is heavily dependent on social transmission. Even a believer who emphasizes personal experience usually acquires the vocabulary, narratives, categories, interpretive possibilities, and background assumptions through which that experience is understood from other people. Scripture itself is encountered through practices of preservation, translation, selection, teaching, and interpretation. Tradition is not merely a collection of old propositions but an inherited context in which present judgement occurs (Halbatal, 1997; Wynn, 2017; Kojonen, 2024).

Second, religious communities assign unequal epistemic roles. A priest, theologian, elder, jurist, scholar, mystic, parent, local teacher, canonical author, institutional body, or ordinary believer may each have different standing. Authority can be formal or informal, local or universal, defeasible or nearly final. It may derive from office, expertise, lineage, sanctity, tradition, communal recognition, claimed revelation, or some combination of these. Social epistemology has long stressed that knowing often depends on testimony, trust, expertise, and distributed epistemic labour (Hardwig, 1985; Lackey, 2008; Zagzebski, 2012). Religious disagreement sharpens that dependence because the relevant authorities may claim not only expertise but stewardship of sacred meaning, tradition, and communal identity.

This means that the question "How should I respond to disagreement?" is downstream from another question:

Who was allowed to become an epistemically significant disagreeer in the first place?

A tradition that centralizes doctrinal authority may prevent some disagreements from reaching ordinary members as live options. A tradition with many semi-independent interpretive centers may expose members to a greater range of competing views. A tradition may preserve dissenting arguments in its educational canon, or it may record only the resolution. It may treat certain sources as final, presumptively authoritative, or merely advisory. These choices influence the evidential landscape available to the believer.

This is also why epistemic injustice and hermeneutical access matter for religious authority. If some voices are structurally discounted as knowers, or if a community lacks stable categories for making certain experiences intelligible, then disagreement may be suppressed before it appears as a philosophical disagreement at all (Fricker, 2007). An architectural account can therefore ask not only whether dissenters are right, but whether a community has preserved enough epistemic space for relevant dissent to become audible, assessable, and corrigible.

3. Sacred Sovereignty and Epistemic Distribution

Comparisons between polytheistic and monotheistic traditions often treat them as broad structural architectures for distributing sacred authority, regulating variation, forming canons, and sustaining institutional coherence (Burkert, 1985; Parker, 2005; Assmann, 2010). That macro comparison is useful but potentially misleading unless two axes are separated. As Smith (2004) cautions in a different register, comparison is an interpretive act; it should clarify selected relations rather than pretend to exhaust the traditions compared.

Sacred sovereignty concerns where legitimate divine authority is claimed ultimately to terminate. A monotheistic architecture grounds legitimate sacred authority in a single divine source, however many subordinate figures, offices, messengers, saints, councils, or institutions appear downstream. A polytheistic architecture permits multiple divine authorities with irreducible standing, even where one deity has primacy, kingship, or superior rank.

Epistemic distribution concerns the human pathways through which sacred authority is interpreted, transmitted, contested, and applied. These pathways include scripture, tradition, commentary, priesthoods, jurists, elders, theologians, councils, local communities, ritual specialists, individual conscience, and lived practice.

The two axes are related, but they are not identical. A monotheistic tradition may affirm one ultimate divine source while distributing interpretation widely among schools, local communities, scholars, or individual readers. A polytheistic tradition may recognize multiple divine authorities while centralizing human mediation through priesthood, civic institutions, or ritual office.

This distinction prevents two errors. The first is head-counting: treating the number of divine beings, intermediaries, or offices as sufficient to classify epistemic structure. The second is architectural determinism: assuming that sacred sovereignty mechanically determines human authority distribution. Real traditions are hybrid and historically variable. The proper unit of analysis is not "monotheism is centralized" or "polytheism is distributed," but "this function, in this tradition, allocates authority in this way."

4. Two-Axis Model

Separating sacred sovereignty and epistemic distribution yields four structural possibilities.

Sacred sovereignty	Human epistemic distribution	Structural possibility
Singular or exclusive	Concentrated	One ultimate divine source with narrow authoritative interpretation
Singular or exclusive	Distributed	One ultimate divine source with multiple legitimate interpretive pathways
Plural or irreducible	Concentrated	Multiple divine authorities with centralized human mediation
Plural or irreducible	Distributed	Multiple divine authorities with multiple semi-independent interpretive pathways

This model is not a taxonomy of religions. It is a diagnostic grid for functions inside traditions. The same tradition may distribute textual interpretation differently from ritual authority, local practice, institutional discipline, or individual conscience. A tradition may also shift over time, centralizing one layer while decentralizing another.

The model also clarifies why structural analogy is safer than genealogical causation. The paper does not claim that a modern institution descends from a particular religious form, nor that a contemporary religious community can be reduced to a single cell in the grid. It claims that human communities repeatedly face problems of authority, coordination, error, and correction, and that the distribution of authority changes how those problems behave.

The grid is best applied through mechanism-level examples. A Christian tradition may affirm one divine source while distributing interpretive responsibility differently across scripture, magisterial office, local church practice, theological scholarship, and individual conscience. A Jewish legal or interpretive tradition may preserve disagreement through commentary, precedent, and recorded minority positions without treating every preserved view as presently authoritative. A civic polytheistic tradition may acknowledge multiple divine powers while concentrating ritual authorization in offices, calendars, or civic institutions. These examples do not classify whole religions. They show why the same tradition may be concentrated for one function and distributed for another.

5. Concentrated and Distributed Authority

At the downstream epistemic level, two ideal types are useful: concentrated epistemic authority and distributed epistemic authority.

An epistemic system is relatively concentrated when a small number of recognized nodes have unusually high power to stabilize contested belief. These nodes might include a central institution, a canonical text under privileged interpretive rules, a council, a scholarly hierarchy, an office, or a widely recognized tradition.

Concentration has real virtues. It reduces coordination costs, provides shared reference points, preserves continuity across time and geography, and can protect against rapid fragmentation. It may also preserve expertise by recognizing that some questions require linguistic, historical, legal, ritual, or theological competence.

The danger is error amplification. If a highly authoritative node adopts a mistaken interpretation, the mistake can propagate widely before alternative assessments survive or gain standing. If the same authority also controls the mechanisms by which it is reviewed, correction becomes structurally expensive. The problem is not merely that authorities can be wrong. The problem is that being wrong in one place can synchronize error elsewhere.

An epistemic system is relatively distributed when interpretive authority is spread across multiple semi-independent nodes: local communities, schools, scholars, lineages, practices, specialists, or individual interpreters whose standing is not wholly derivative from one central authority.

Distribution also has virtues. It preserves local knowledge, interpretive redundancy, minority traditions, independent routes of correction, and alternative responses to new circumstances. Errors may remain local rather than system-wide. Dissent can survive long enough to accumulate reasons, evidence, and institutional memory.

The danger is convergence cost. Interpretations may multiply without shared criteria for comparison. Local errors can persist indefinitely. Communities can fracture. Members may choose authorities opportunistically. Shared vocabulary can weaken until groups retain a label while no longer sharing enough structure to disagree productively.

The point is not that one ideal type is better. Concentration protects against fragmentation while risking synchronized error. Distribution protects against capture while risking incoherence. Each solves a problem partly created by the other.

6. The Correction Problem

The deepest issue is correction. Religious traditions are temporally extended. They inherit claims from past communities, preserve texts under conditions not fully recoverable, encounter new evidence and moral questions, and must decide whether later developments preserve or distort earlier commitments.

Even a community that affirms infallible divine authority relies on fallible human agents to identify, transmit, translate, interpret, teach, and apply that authority. The philosophical problem begins where fallible people must recognize and mediate putatively infallible sources.

This creates a structural question:

How can a community preserve enough continuity to remain the same tradition while preserving enough independent judgement to recognize when inherited interpretation is wrong?

Too little continuity and correction becomes indistinguishable from replacement. Too little corrigibility and continuity becomes entrenchment. A robust religious epistemology therefore cannot ask only what an individual should believe after disagreement. It must also ask how a tradition stores past disagreement, recognizes expertise, handles dissent, reviews settled questions, and prevents authority from becoming self-validating.

Correction is especially difficult when defeated interpretations disappear. A future community may possess evidence unavailable to an earlier one. If the earlier dispute has been compressed into "question resolved," later participants inherit a conclusion without the epistemic landscape from which it emerged. Preserved dissent does not mean equal endorsement. It means maintaining access to reasons, objections, and minority reports so that future review remains possible.

This yields the paper's central mechanism:

Epistemic corrigibility requires not merely permission to disagree, but durable access to alternative interpretations, reasons for past decisions, and routes by which settled authority can be reconsidered.

7. Bounded Pluralism

Bounded pluralism names the proposed middle architecture. It is not a theological doctrine and does not imply that all claims are equally true. It is an epistemic design principle: preserve multiple sites of competent judgement inside a shared framework strong enough to sustain mutual intelligibility.

The bounded component matters because unlimited interpretive proliferation can destroy the common reference points that make disagreement meaningful. If communities no longer share texts, standards, practices, vocabulary, or criteria of relevance, apparent disagreement may become equivocation between different traditions.

The pluralism component matters because a single legitimate route of interpretation can produce coherence at the cost of redundancy. Correction then depends heavily on the reliability and self-correcting capacity of that route.

A bounded-pluralist architecture has at least five features.

First, it has shared but non-exhaustive reference points. A tradition needs enough common material for disagreement to have an object: texts, narratives, rituals, historical memories, or high-level principles. But shared reference points need not determine every downstream interpretation.

Second, it has multiple legitimate interpretive sites. Different questions may require different competence: language, history, lived practice, moral reasoning, ritual knowledge, systematic theology, or local judgement. Hierarchy may remain, but it should not erase the legitimacy of differentiated expertise.

Third, it preserves dissent. Archives, recorded objections, minority reports, rival commentaries, and remembered controversies preserve evidence about a community's own uncertainty. Preservation is not endorsement. It is epistemic memory.

Fourth, it allows review without permanent instability. If every decision can be reopened at any moment, common practice becomes impossible. If no decision can be reopened, correction becomes impossible. Bounded pluralism therefore needs thresholds for review: new evidence, changed circumstances, serious contradiction, relevant expertise, or persistent unresolved disagreement.

Fifth, it permits authority to be strong without being self-validating. No complex tradition eliminates circularity entirely, since people learn who to trust partly from trusted sources. But degrees matter. Independent archives, multiple institutions, local practices, and distinct forms of expertise can create partial checks.

Bounded pluralism therefore aims not at authority-free religion, but at authority with redundancy.

8. Religious Disagreement Revisited

An architectural perspective changes the standard disagreement problem. When A learns that B disagrees, A's judgement about B's competence is itself shaped by an inherited authority structure. A may have been taught that a certain office has privileged interpretive authority, that a text overrides testimony, that another tradition lacks necessary insight, or that personal experience has special standing. B may inherit a different ranking.

Some religious disagreements are therefore second-order architectural disagreements. The parties do not merely disagree about a proposition. They disagree about who is authorized to interpret evidence, what counts as expertise, how tradition weighs against individual judgement, which institutions transmit revelation reliably, and what would count as a defeater for authority.

These disputes cannot be solved by simply adding more first-order evidence, because the parties may use different rules for weighting evidence. Dialogue may need to move from propositions to epistemic roles:

1. Why does this source receive authority?

2. What would count as a defeater for that authority?
3. Who may identify such a defeater?
4. How is dissent preserved?
5. What makes an interpreter competent?
6. What happens when recognized authorities conflict?
7. Which judgements are revisable, and by what process?

This also shows why visible plurality is not enough. A community can contain many voices while routing authoritative decisions through one gate. Conversely, an institutionally centralized tradition can preserve meaningful scholarly, local, or interpretive independence beneath the surface. The number of speakers is not the same as the distribution of authority.

9. Relation to Modern Institutions

The broader project compares religious architectures with modern secular institutions. Professional specialization, academic disciplines, and networked innovation ecosystems can resemble distributed models of competence. Constitutions, legal codes, corporate brands, and regulatory regimes can resemble centralized models of canonical unity. These are structural analogies, not claims of direct historical derivation. They also sit within a wider institutional literature on how communities think, stabilize rules, and govern shared resources (Douglas, 1986; Ostrom, 1990).

The more cautious use of this comparison is diagnostic. Modern institutions also face the continuity-correction problem. Scientific fields need shared standards without suppressing dissent. Legal systems need authoritative decisions without making error unrecoverable. Universities need disciplinary autonomy without fragmentation. Regulatory regimes need coherence without local blindness.

Religious traditions are useful cases because they are long-lived, textually mediated, normatively serious, and unusually explicit about authority. They show how communities can preserve common identity while allocating interpretive power across texts, offices, practices, specialists, and local judgement. Studying them structurally can therefore contribute to institutional epistemology more broadly.

The analogy should remain bounded. Secular institutions are not secretly religious because they share some organizational patterns. The claim is that human societies repeatedly face similar coordination problems and often develop structurally comparable solutions.

10. Objections

One objection is that truth matters, not architecture. A false distributed system remains false, while a true centralized authority may transmit truth efficiently.

The reply is that architecture is not a substitute for truth. It concerns the conditions under which fallible humans acquire, preserve, and correct beliefs about truth. Even if a tradition begins from true revelation, members still face questions of interpretation and transmission.

A second objection is that the model romanticizes decentralization. Distributed systems can generate misinformation, factionalism, charismatic local authority, and endless drift.

The reply is agreement. The paper rejects maximal decentralization. Distribution lowers some risks while raising others. Bounded pluralism is proposed precisely because plurality without shared structure can fragment.

A third objection is that religious authority is divine, not institutional.

The reply is that divine source and human access must be distinguished. If God reveals truth, humans still decide which event, text, testimony, institution, or experience genuinely carries revelation and how it should be interpreted. Strong divine authority can make human mediation more important, not less, because misidentifying a human judgement as divinely guaranteed raises correction costs.

A fourth objection is that the concentrated/distributed distinction is too coarse.

The reply is that it is an ideal-type instrument, not a taxonomy of religions. It should be applied at mechanism level: canon, local practice, ordination, scholarship, ritual authority, private judgement, or institutional review may each distribute authority differently.

A fifth objection is that preserving dissent gives error too much status.

The reply is that preservation is not endorsement. A tradition can settle a question for practice while retaining the discarded path for future understanding. The distinction is between settled for practice and erased from memory.

11. Conclusion

Religious epistemology does not occur only inside individual minds. Religious belief is transmitted through communities that preserve texts, assign authority, recognize experts, remember disputes, teach interpretive practices, and decide which disagreements deserve continued standing. Those arrangements form an epistemic architecture.

Concentrated authority can preserve coherence and continuity, but it increases the risk that authoritative error will propagate widely and become difficult to challenge. Distributed authority can preserve local knowledge and multiple correction routes, but it increases fragmentation and convergence cost. Neither ideal type is sufficient by itself.

The more promising target is bounded pluralism: shared structure without exhaustive centralization, multiple interpretive sites without unlimited fragmentation, preserved dissent without equal endorsement, and review mechanisms that permit correction without making every commitment permanently provisional.

A religious tradition need not choose between continuity and correction. But if it wishes to preserve both, it must preserve not only answers, but the epistemic pathways by which answers can still be questioned.

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